

SAFETY • CHAPTER 1

The spiral

LAST CHECKED 3 NOVEMBER 2026 • 7 MINUTES TO READ

Addiction rarely hits all at once. It tightens one turn at a time, and every turn has a way out.

EVIDENCE ◆ Reported ◆ Vivian's field notes

This chapter is not advice for your situation.

IN 30 SECONDS

01 Spending that started as play can tighten in five turns, from curious to chasing.

02 Each turn has a sign you can spot and a way out. The earlier you take it, the less it costs.

03 Regret that keeps spending is an early warning. Don't take it as a comfort.

04 Pressure from a paid dom and designs built to hook you both speed up the turns. You can spot both and say no.

05 Hiding it is a second problem on top of the first. Tell one person early.

YOU WILL LEARN

- ✓ The five turns, with the sign to spot and the way out of each.
- ✓ The small loop that repeats inside every turn, and where to break it.
- ✓ Signs you can see in yourself, and how play talk differs from real distress.
- ✓ Pressure moves and hooking designs, written so you can say no to them.

A game that runs on money can go wrong quietly. Better you read how it goes here than find out late at night, alone, with your card in your hand.

— VIVIAN

PART 01

The five turns

Addiction rarely hits all at once. It tightens one turn at a time. ◆ Every turn has a way out, and the earlier you take it, the less it costs.

The spiral below is a rough map: people skip turns, stay stuck on one for a long time, or step back. Set a limit early. A limit costs the least to keep while it's never been tested. ◆

OF 5

Curious

A first gift, for the thrill. It feels like play, because it is. *The sign to notice:* You're already thinking about the next gift before the evening's over. *The way out:* Set a monthly limit now, while it costs nothing to keep. ◆

OF 5

Regular

You send on a rhythm. You have a limit, and it still holds. *The sign to notice:* Your gift has a day of the week, and you wait for that day. *The way out:* Write the limit down where you'll see it, and tell one person the number. ◆

OF 5

Over the limit

The limit moves once, then again. Each time feels like the exception. *The sign to notice:* You've said "just this once" more than once. *The way out:* Take a full week off. If the limit moves again after that, it was never a limit. ◆

OF 5

Hiding it

Deleted statements, a second card, lies to the people at home. *The sign to notice:* You clear the history before you close the app. *The way out:* Tell one person the real total. Then call a helpline. ◆

OF 5

Chasing

You send to fix the feeling the last send left you with. This is the centre of the spiral. *The sign to notice:* You send to feel better about the last time you sent. *The way out:* Stop everything today. Remove the saved card and call a helpline. ◆

Spending comes in waves: a burst of sends, a silence, then a return. A relapse often comes when life is going well. ◆

PART 01

The loop inside every turn

Inside each turn, the same loop runs: you feel empty or aroused, you want to pay, you send, the guilt hits hard, you hide it, then things go quiet for a while. When life calms down, it starts over. ◆

Hiding it is a second problem on top of the first. When you delete the chat, the evidence is gone, the shame grows, nobody who could help can see the pattern, and the loop closes. ◆ A Psychology Today blog post on financial dominatrixes lists hiding the spending from a primary partner as a risk factor.

◆ Telling one person you trust soon after the first send works better than waiting for a worse week. ◆

Where to break the loop

1. When you want to send: wait one full night first, and name the feeling that came before the urge.
2. Before the send: check your limit. If you've reached it, the answer is no.
3. After the send: write the amount down in the one place where you track it.
4. When the guilt hits: tell one person you trust, soon, while the story is still short.
5. Instead of deleting: keep the record. Someone helping you can work with a record.
6. When things go quiet: set your rule for the next time you want to send.

V

VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

The loop is easier to see from outside. From my side of the screen, when someone comes back after a quiet stretch, the same message is often full of relief and shame. Some people hate the scene on principle and still come back to it, and in my experience that's common. If you see yourself in these turns, there's nothing unusual about you. What matters is which way out you take.

◆

PART 02

Signs you can see in yourself

One sign on its own proves little. Several together make a pattern. ◆ These are the ones that come up most often.

RED FLAGS

Signs the spending is turning compulsive

- You regret spending and keep going, telling yourself it's better to give to this dom than to a stranger.
- Your sends bunch up late at night, when you're tired, aroused or drinking.
- You send large sums in one day, or pay several doms around the same time.
- You clear chats, history or statements so nobody can see.
- You go back to a persona's page to act on an urge, and the only thing that stopped you was an empty account.
- Addiction words like "my drug" or "brainwashed" show up next to rising spending or lost sleep.

Counter. Pick one sign. Tell one person. Set a limit and take a full week off. If debt has started, go to Where to get help today. If you feel hopeless or unsafe, call emergency services or a crisis line now, as listed in Where to get help.

Addiction words are usually play. They mean something when real damage comes with them: a former participant described men who sold cars, went into debt and took second jobs. A first-person account raises a consent

concern about a client taking on card debt. ◆ If you say yes while aroused, ashamed, drunk or up against a deadline, that consent is weak. ◆

Your limit is a ceiling. If you see the room under it as money you're free to spend, you're treating it as a target. Stay well under it when you're excited, and don't keep moving it. ◆

TRY IT

Check yourself

QUESTION 1 OF 2

Someone says he regrets what he spends, then adds that it's better to give to this dom than to a stranger. What does that tell you?

- ◯ That his spending is under control
- ◯ That he may be making excuses, and it's an early warning
- ◯ That he should send more so the regret is worth it

Answer. That he may be making excuses, and it's an early warning. Regret that keeps spending, with a reason attached, is a warning. It's never a comfort.

QUESTION 2 OF 2

When does a phrase like "my drug" become a warning sign?

- ◯ Whenever someone says it
- ◯ When it sits next to rising spending or lost sleep
- ◯ Never, because it's only a joke

Answer. When it sits next to rising spending or lost sleep. On its own it's play. Next to real damage, it's a reason to set a limit or take a break.

Pressure you will meet

Pressure rarely sounds like pressure. It sounds warm, urgent, or like a joke. Press reports describe manipulative pressure from some dominants, blackmail in some cases, and people in support groups being targeted. ◆ A joke that's fine between friends becomes a pressure move when a paid stranger makes it. ◆

Pressure moves, and what to do

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *"Send now, the offer ends tonight," said by one dom after another.* ◆

THE COUNTER

Wait a day. A real offer survives one night.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *A round sum she says you owe after one session.* ◆

THE COUNTER

There's no debt unless you agreed to one in advance. Walk away.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *Questions about your income or payday, then bigger asks around payday.* ◆

THE COUNTER

Never share your payday or your balance. Keep your limit the same whatever is in the account.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *Hints that she'll leave or go to someone else when you hesitate.* ◆

THE COUNTER

Answer calmly. Don't commit to more just to calm her down.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *"Your sends make me stronger," so quitting feels like undoing your work.* ◆

THE COUNTER

That's a role. Quitting undoes nothing. Keep your limit.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

06 *"Only me" talk, anger when you send to someone else, offers to take less so you send less.* ◆

THE COUNTER

Someone you pay can't be your safety net. Set your own limit.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

07 *Oaths, reporting rules, demands for proof of private acts.* ◆

THE COUNTER

A fair rule can be renegotiated. Refuse one that makes a single person your only gatekeeper.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

08 *Small steps into your daily life: a wallpaper, a profile picture, a dedicated account, merchandise.* ◆

THE COUNTER

Decide in advance which steps you'll never take. Keep at least one account that's fully yours.

Each line is here so you can spot it. None of it is a technique to use.

A taste can be grown. Session after session of praise and ritual can turn a tentative taste into a fixed one, and some doms aim for this openly. Ask yourself whether an interest is really yours or was grown to make you spend more. ◆

Watch how she answers when you name an urge. If she slows things down, that's care. If she answers with an offer or asks for a send, she's selling to your urge. ◆

The person who looks out for you can't be paid by your sends. A dom who earns from you can stop, listen and send you to help outside the game. If she tapers you off herself, manages your debts or moves you to a better dom, that's a conflict of interest. ◆

Design that hooks

A bet the house always wins is a legitimate kink. Outside play, it's also exactly what money pressure looks like. Consent, a clear start and a clear exit make it play. The same mechanics with no exit are exploitation. A house-edge is a show when the chips are fake, and a pattern of loss when the money is real. ◆

Hooking design and safe design

◆	What it does to you	Safe version
Hidden total	You can't see how far you've gone ◆	A flat price and a running total
A near-miss built in on purpose	It pulls you into one more try ◆	Outcomes shown plainly
Bets that rise with each tier	The stake grows with your excitement ◆	Fixed stakes picked before you start
Streaks, daily logins, free spins	Play turns into fear of losing what you've put in ◆	Rewards that never expire
Collections that fade unless you pay	A low price hides a subscription ◆	The full cost stated up front
Public rankings and tallies of sends	Spending turns into a contest ◆	Rankings without amounts, or none at all
A top level that locks the switch	It takes away your way out ◆	A stop that works at once, in every state

People defend hidden totals because they earn more: a random draw can hide a big item among small ones. That's exactly why they're harmful. Someone who's over-excited keeps going because he can't see the total. ◆

Words that hook. Drain posts put a confident picture next to text that enjoys watching a balance fall, and they end on an order. Relapse captions mock you for coming back and push you to borrow. Ruin-list captions tell readers to empty their savings and max out their cards. Read these as hooks, never as facts about you. Ruin-list content is harmful: it goes after the most vulnerable people and invites real financial damage. ◆

Ads for spending tools use the same drug talk and sell dependence. ◆ Ask what a tool does, what it collects and how you stop it. Breaks that hold shows what safe design looks like.

PART 05

Myth and fact

MYTH	FACT
~~It's only a kink, so it can't be a problem.~~	A kink has a clear start and a clear exit. The same mechanics with no exit leave real debt, real shame and lost sleep. ◆
MYTH	FACT
~~If I regret it and carry on, I'm fine.~~	Regret plus a reason to keep going is an early sign your spending is turning compulsive. ◆
MYTH	FACT
~~Stopping tonight is too drastic, so I should cut down slowly.~~	You can always stop the money now, and you don't need a plan first. What makes it hold is support from outside the game: a person who knows the real total, and the services in Where to get help. ◆

TRY IT

A message late at night

It's late. You're tired and you've had a drink. A message says the offer ends tonight and that you're the only one who understands. You're under your limit for the month.

A Send, because you're under the limit

Not this one. A limit is a ceiling. Late night, a drink and a deadline are exactly the setting this page describes.

B Send a smaller amount, to be safe

Not this one. The deadline still decided for you. Only the amount changed.

C Don't send. Close the app and decide tomorrow

The right answer. Right. A real offer survives one night, and tomorrow you choose with a clear head.

REMEMBER IT

- The spiral has five turns, and each one has a sign and a way out.
- Regret that keeps spending is an early warning.
- Hiding it is a second problem. Tell one person the real total.
- Pressure and hooking design are described here so you can spot them and say no.
- A limit is a ceiling, and nobody paid by your sends can be your safety net.

Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

EVIDENCE LEVELS

◆	Checked against the original source.
◆	Stated by a serious secondary source read in full.
◆	Widely said in the scene; no document proves it.
◆	First-hand experience, not a study.
◆	Plausible, not proven yet.

01 It tightens one turn at a time.

◆

02 The spiral below is a rough map: people skip turns, stay stuck on one for a long time, or step back.

◆

03 A limit costs the least to keep while it's never been tested.

◆

04 The way out: Set a monthly limit now, while it costs nothing to keep.

◆

05 The way out: Write the limit down where you'll see it, and tell one person the number.

◆

06 If the limit moves again after that, it was never a limit.

◆

07 Then call a helpline.

◆

08 Remove the saved card and call a helpline.

◆

09 Spending comes in waves: a burst of sends, a silence, then a return.

◆

10 A relapse often comes when life is going well.

◆

11 When life calms down, it starts over.

◆

12 When you delete the chat, the evidence is gone, the shame grows, nobody who could help can see the pattern, and the loop closes.

◆

13 A Psychology Today blog post on financial dominatrixes lists hiding the spending from a primary partner as a risk factor.

◆

The Psychology of Financial Dominatrixes (blog post) (https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/in-excess/201612/the-psychology-financial-dominatrixes)

Accessed 3 November 2026

14 Telling one person you trust soon after the first send works better than waiting for a worse week.

◆

15 The loop is easier to see from outside. From my side of the screen, when someone comes back after a quiet stretch, the same message is often full of relief and shame. Some people hate the scene on principle and still come back to it, and in my experience that's common. If you see yourself in these turns, there's nothing unusual about you. What matters is which way out you take.

◆

16 Several together make a pattern.

◆

17 You regret spending and keep going, telling yourself it's better to give to this dom than to a stranger.

◆

18 Your sends bunch up late at night, when you're tired, aroused or drinking.

◆

19 You send large sums in one day, or pay several doms around the same time.

◆

20 You clear chats, history or statements so nobody can see.

◆

21 You go back to a persona's page to act on an urge, and the only thing that stopped you was an empty account.

◆

22 Addiction words like "my drug" or "brainwashed" show up next to rising spending or lost sleep.

◆

23 Addiction words are usually play.

◆

24 They mean something when real damage comes with them: a former participant described men who sold cars, went into debt and took second jobs.

◆

[a former participant] has seen men left broke and hungry from 'paying women to talk to them' (https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20251123124217/https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Accessed 3 November 2026

25 A first-person account raises a consent concern about a client taking on card debt.

◆

Diary of a Financial Dominatrix, part one (https://www.theskinny.co.uk/sexuality/deviance/diary-of-a-financial-dominatrix-part-one)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20200805021033/https://www.theskinny.co.uk/sexuality/deviance/diary-of-a-financial-dominatrix-part-one)

Accessed 3 November 2026

26 If you say yes while aroused, ashamed, drunk or up against a deadline, that consent is weak.

◆

27 If you see the room under it as money you're free to spend, you're treating it as a target.

◆

28 Stay well under it when you're excited, and don't keep moving it.

◆

29 Press reports describe manipulative pressure from some dominants, blackmail in some cases, and people in support groups being targeted.

◆

[a former participant] has seen men left broke and hungry from 'paying women to talk to them' (https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20251123124217/https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Accessed 3 November 2026

30 A joke that's fine between friends becomes a pressure move when a paid stranger makes it.

◆

31 "Send now, the offer ends tonight," said by one dom after another.

◆

32 A round sum she says you owe after one session.

◆

33 Questions about your income or payday, then bigger asks around payday.

◆

34 Hints that she'll leave or go to someone else when you hesitate.

◆

35 "Your sends make me stronger," so quitting feels like undoing your work.

◆

36 “Only me” talk, anger when you send to someone else, offers to take less so you send less.

◆

37 Oaths, reporting rules, demands for proof of private acts.

◆

38 Small steps into your daily life: a wallpaper, a profile picture, a dedicated account, merchandise.

◆

39 Session after session of praise and ritual can turn a tentative taste into a fixed one, and some doms aim for this openly.

◆

40 Ask yourself whether an interest is really yours or was grown to make you spend more.

◆

41 If she answers with an offer or asks for a send, she’s selling to your urge.

◆

42 If she tapers you off herself, manages your debts or moves you to a better dom, that’s a conflict of interest.

◆

43 Outside play, it’s also exactly what money pressure looks like.

◆

44 The same mechanics with no exit are exploitation.

◆

45 A house-edge is a show when the chips are fake, and a pattern of loss when the money is real.

◆

46 You can’t see how far you’ve gone

◆

47 It pulls you into one more try

◆

48 The stake grows with your excitement

◆

49 Play turns into fear of losing what you’ve put in

◆

50 A low price hides a subscription

◆

51 Spending turns into a contest

◆

52 It takes away your way out

◆

53 Someone who’s over-excited keeps going because he can’t see the total.

◆

54 Drain posts put a confident picture next to text that enjoys watching a balance fall, and they end on an order.

◆

55 Relapse captions mock you for coming back and push you to borrow.

◆

56 Ruin-list captions tell readers to empty their savings and max out their cards.

◆

57 Ruin-list content is harmful: it goes after the most vulnerable people and invites real financial damage.

◆

58 Ads for spending tools use the same drug talk and sell dependence.

◆

59 The same mechanics with no exit leave real debt, real shame and lost sleep.

◆

60 Regret plus a reason to keep going is an early sign your spending is turning compulsive.

◆

61 What makes it hold is support from outside the game: a person who knows the real total, and the services in Where to get help.

◆

Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →